
Speak and Write on Any Topic

A 24-week roadmap from CEFR B2 to C2

- Daily routines, weekly targets and monthly milestones
- Frameworks for instant structure: speeches and magazine articles
- Level-by-level upgrade guide with model sentences
- Curated resources, tests and a progress tracker

START HERE

The Big Idea

Speaking or writing well on an unfamiliar topic is not a talent. It is a system with four moving parts, and each one can be trained separately and then combined:

Part	What it means	How you train it
1. Ideas	Finding something worth saying in under two minutes	Five Lenses brainstorm, daily news reading, opinion journal
2. Structure	Arranging ideas so the listener or reader never gets lost	PREP, the 3-point speech, the article skeleton
3. Language	Precise vocabulary, collocations, varied grammar, natural connectors	Active vocabulary notebook, sentence upgrading, shadowing
4. Delivery and style	Voice, pace, rhythm, tone, and a distinctive writing voice	Recording yourself, timed drills, editing and rewriting

What each level looks like in practice

Level	Speaking	Writing
B2 Independent	Talk fluently and spontaneously about many topics with reasonable accuracy. Give clear viewpoints and reasons. Occasional hesitation and repetition.	Clear, detailed texts: essays, reports, reviews. Arguments are organised, but vocabulary is often general and sentences are similar in shape.
C1 Proficient	Express ideas fluently with little searching for words. Use language flexibly for social, academic and professional purposes. Well-controlled organisation and connectors.	Well-structured, detailed texts on complex subjects. Good control of tone, cohesion, and a wide range of vocabulary including idiom and collocation.
C2 Mastery	Convey finer shades of meaning precisely. Adjust style instantly. Recover smoothly from any slip. Speak with rhythm, emphasis and irony where suitable.	Polished, stylistically appropriate prose. Logical structure helps the reader find key points. Distinct voice, economy, and rhetorical control.

Who this roadmap assumes

You start at solid B1+ to B2, can hold a conversation, and can commit about 90 minutes a day (or 30 minutes if you follow the compressed plan on the last page). If you are already comfortable at B2, begin at Week 9 and treat Phase 1 as a diagnostic.

THE PLAN AT A GLANCE

24-Week Timeline

Phase	Weeks	Target	Main skills	Milestone
Phase 1 Foundation	1 - 8	Secure B2, reach early C1	Fluency habit, 3 core structures, 1,000 active words and phrases, clear paragraphs	Week 8: 2-minute impromptu speech and 400-word article on a random topic
Phase 2 Expansion	9 - 16	Solid C1	Range and precision, collocations, argument and counter-argument, tone control, 700-word features	Week 16: 3-minute speech with rebuttal and 700-word magazine-style piece
Phase 3 Mastery	17 - 24	Working C2	Style, rhythm, rhetoric, humour and irony, speed under pressure, editing to a professional standard	Week 24: 5-minute talk, 1-minute impromptu and 1,000-word feature, all on unseen topics

Your daily 90-minute routine

Block	Time	What to do
Input	20 min	Read one quality article or listen to one talk. Underline 5 useful phrases (not single words). Note the structure: how did the writer open, turn, and close?
Vocabulary	15 min	Add phrases to your notebook or Anki deck. Write one original sentence for each. Review yesterday's list aloud.
Speaking drill	25 min	Rotate: shadowing (Mon), 60-second topic talk (Tue), 2-minute PREP talk (Wed), retell an article (Thu), record and review (Fri).
Writing drill	25 min	Rotate: sentence upgrading (Mon), paragraph (Tue), outline plus intro (Wed), full short piece (Thu), edit yesterday's piece (Fri).
Review	5 min	Log one thing that improved and one error you keep repeating.

Weekend rhythm

- **Saturday:** One longer task. Deliver a full speech to a friend, tutor or Toastmasters club, or write a full article. Get feedback.
- **Sunday:** Rest your mouth and pen. Do light input only: a podcast or long read. Plan the next week's topics.

The one rule that makes it work

Never let a day pass without producing language out loud *and* on paper. Input alone builds recognition. Only output builds the ability to speak or write on demand.

PHASE 1 | WEEKS 1 - 8

Foundation: Fluency and Structure

Goal: stop translating in your head, and learn three structures that let you organise any thought in seconds.

Week	Speaking focus	Writing focus	Language focus
1	Baseline: record a 2-minute talk on 'my city' and a 250-word piece. Keep both. Begin shadowing 5 min daily.	Simple paragraph: topic sentence, support, example, closing line	Linking words: however, therefore, in addition, for instance
2	60-second talks on daily-life topics. No pausing to plan.	Paragraph unity. Cut every sentence that does not serve the topic sentence.	Present perfect vs past simple; time expressions
3	PREP structure: Point, Reason, Example, Point again	Opinion paragraph using PREP	Opinion phrases: I would argue, it seems to me, I am convinced that
4	2-minute PREP talks on social topics (education, transport, work)	Four-paragraph essay: intro, two body, conclusion (300 words)	Conditionals 0-3; mixed conditionals
5	Reduce fillers (um, like, you know). Replace with a silent pause.	Rewrite last week's essay. Combine short sentences.	Relative clauses; participle phrases
6	3-point speech: three reasons or three examples. Signpost clearly.	Introductions: hook, context, thesis	Passive voice for formal writing; nominalisation basics
7	Describe graphs, trends and processes aloud	Summarise an article in 120 words, then in 60	Collocations for change: sharp rise, steady decline, plateau
8	Milestone: 2-minute impromptu speech on a topic drawn at random	Milestone: 400-word article on a random topic in 40 minutes	Consolidation and error review

Core toolkit for Phase 1

- **Active vocabulary target:** 20 new phrases a week, 160 by Week 8, plus revision of earlier ones. Learn chunks such as 'raise awareness of', not lone words.
- **Shadowing method:** play 30 seconds of a talk, repeat it at the same speed while imitating rhythm and stress. Repeat the same clip for three days.
- **Error notebook:** write each recurring mistake with its correction. Review it every Friday.
- **Pass mark for Phase 1:** you can talk for 2 minutes without stopping, with a clear opening, three ideas and a close.

PHASE 2 | WEEKS 9 - 16

Expansion: Range, Precision and Argument

Goal: replace general words with exact ones, argue both sides, and adapt tone to the audience.

Week	Speaking focus	Writing focus	Language focus
9	3-minute talks. Add a story or personal anecdote to open.	Feature-style openings: scene, question, surprising fact	Narrative tenses; vivid verbs
10	Argument and counter-argument: 'Some people say... but...'	Balanced essay with concession and rebuttal	Concession: admittedly, granted, even though, whereas
11	Explain complex ideas simply using analogy and example	Explainer article (500 words) on a technical topic	Abstract nouns; academic collocations
12	Answer unexpected follow-up questions (Q&A; drill with a partner)	Sentence variety: mix short, medium and long sentences	Inversion for emphasis: Rarely do we, Not only did
13	Register shifts: same message to a friend, a boss and a conference	Rewrite one text in three registers	Idiom and phrasal verbs in context (2 to 3 a day, not more)
14	Persuasion: emotion, logic, credibility. Deliver a call to action.	Op-ed of 600 words with a clear position	Hedging and boosting: arguably, undoubtedly, to some extent
15	Use pauses, emphasis and pace deliberately. Mark up a script with slashes.	Cohesion: reference words, parallelism, signposting	Cleft sentences: What matters is..., It was X that...
16	Milestone: 3-minute speech with a rebuttal on a random topic	Milestone: 700-word magazine-style piece in 60 minutes	Consolidation and error review

Core toolkit for Phase 2

- **Active vocabulary target:** 25 new phrases a week, focusing on collocations, formal and informal alternatives, and topic sets (economy, health, technology, environment, culture, politics, education).
- **Weekly topic bank:** choose 3 topics you know little about. For each, read two articles from opposing viewpoints and build a 'cheat sheet' of 5 facts, 3 arguments and 2 counter-arguments.
- **Retell and reduce:** after each talk, listen to yourself and cut it by 20%. Concision is the sign of command.
- **Pass mark for Phase 2:** you can defend a position, acknowledge the other side, and stay in control when someone interrupts you.

PHASE 3 | WEEKS 17 - 24

Mastery: Style, Rhythm and Speed

Goal: sound like yourself at your best. Precision, economy and a recognisable voice, on any subject, at short notice.

Week	Speaking focus	Writing focus	Language focus
17	Rhetorical devices: rule of three, contrast, repetition, rhetorical question	Analyse two magazine features: annotate every device used	Parallel structure; antithesis
18	Storytelling arc: setup, tension, turn, resolution (4 minutes)	Long-form opening of 300 words that makes the reader continue	Show, don't tell; concrete detail
19	Humour and irony: understatement, wit, self-deprecation (use sparingly)	Tone control: rewrite a dry text as warm, then as sharp	Nuance verbs and adjectives: insist vs maintain vs contend
20	Impromptu speaking: 30 seconds to plan, 2 minutes to deliver	Timed writing: 500 words in 30 minutes, minimal editing	Subtle discourse markers; ellipsis and substitution
21	Handle hostile questions and recover from errors gracefully	Cut 20% from any draft without losing meaning	Precision: replace every 'very + adjective' with one exact word
22	Deliver from bullet points only, never from a script	Write a headline, standfirst and pull-quote for each piece	Register-perfect vocabulary for academic, journalistic and business contexts
23	Full simulation: strangers as audience (club, class or online)	Full editorial cycle: draft, sleep on it, edit, proofread	Personal style audit: your habits, favourites, weak spots
24	Milestone: 5-minute talk plus a 1-minute impromptu on unseen topics	Milestone: 1,000-word feature with headline and standfirst	Final review; plan for ongoing practice

Core toolkit for Phase 3

- **Speak from ideas, not words.** Rehearse the sequence of ideas, never the sentences. Words come fresh each time, which is what makes speech sound alive.
- **Steal like a writer.** Copy out one excellent paragraph by hand each week, then write your own on a different subject in the same rhythm.
- **Edit hard.** Read every draft aloud. Anything that trips your tongue will trip the reader. Cut adverbs, weak openings and repeated ideas.
- **Pass mark for Phase 3:** a fair listener could not guess you learned English as an additional language from your structure and word choice. Small accent or rare slips are perfectly fine.

YOUR EVERYDAY WEAPONS

The Any-Topic Toolkit

These four tools work at every level. Practise them until they are automatic.

1. The Five Lenses (60-second brainstorm)

Given any topic, ask five questions. You will nearly always find three usable ideas.

Lens	Question to ask	Example: 'Remote work'
Human	Who is affected, and how does it feel to them?	Isolation for some, freedom for parents and carers
Money	Who pays, who gains, what does it cost?	Office rent savings vs home-setup costs
Technology	What enables or changes it?	Video tools, cloud software, cybersecurity risks
Society	What does it do to fairness, culture or values?	Widens gap between remote-friendly and on-site jobs
Time	What was it like before, and where is it heading?	Pre-2020 norms, hybrid as the likely long-term model

2. PREP for any speech of 1 to 2 minutes

P	Point	State your position in one clear sentence.
R	Reason	Give the main reason: 'This matters because...'
E	Example	A concrete case, statistic or story.
P	Point	Restate the position in fresh words, ideally with a call to action.

3. The article skeleton (400 to 1,000 words)

Part	Job	Length guide
Hook	Scene, question or surprising fact that earns the next paragraph	2 to 3 sentences
Nut paragraph	Tell the reader what this is about and why it matters now	1 paragraph
Body: 3 points	Each: claim, evidence, example, mini-conclusion	2 to 4 paragraphs
Counterpoint	The best opposing view, treated fairly	1 paragraph
Kicker	Return to the hook. Leave a thought, not a summary.	2 to 3 sentences

4. Sentence upgrading: the fastest way to climb levels

Take one idea and write it at three levels. Do this daily with one sentence from your own writing.

Level	Example
B2	Social media is bad for teenagers because it makes them feel worried and they use it too much.
C1	Excessive use of social media has been linked to heightened anxiety among teenagers, who are especially vulnerable to constant comparison.
C2	For a generation raised on the scroll, the feed has become less a window onto friends than a mirror that flatters no one, and anxiety is the price of admission.

Transition bank: memorise one new item a day**B2:** On the other hand / As a result / For example / In conclusion**C1:** That said / Consequently / A case in point is / Taking everything into account**C2:** Be that as it may / By the same token / Tellingly / All of which points to**BUILD YOUR LIBRARY**

Recommended Resources

Pick a small number and use them consistently. More resources do not mean more progress.

Reading models (your writing teachers)

Resource	Best for	Level
The Economist (especially Leaders and 'Espresso' briefings)	Compact argument, precise vocabulary, dry wit	B2 to C2
The Guardian (Opinion and Long Read)	Persuasion, storytelling, varied tone	B2 to C2
BBC News and BBC Future	Clear, neutral explanatory writing	B2 to C1
The Atlantic, The New Yorker, Aeon, Longreads	Long-form features, style, voice	C1 to C2
George Orwell, essay 'Politics and the English Language'	Timeless lessons in clarity and honest prose	C1 to C2

Listening and speaking models

Resource	Best for	Level
BBC Learning English: 6 Minute English	Discussion language with transcripts	B2
TED and TEDx talks (with transcripts)	Talk structure, openings, delivery. Study 1 talk a week.	B2 to C2
BBC Radio 4: In Our Time, Start the Week	Sophisticated spoken argument	C1 to C2
Intelligence Squared debates (podcast and video)	Rebuttal, persuasion, handling pressure	C1 to C2
The Economist, Guardian and NYT daily podcasts	Current affairs vocabulary, natural pace	C1 to C2

Books

Title	Why it helps
<i>English Grammar in Use (Intermediate), Advanced Grammar in Use (Cambridge)</i>	Fill grammar gaps quickly. Use as reference, not cover to cover.
<i>English Collocations in Use (Advanced), Oxford Collocations Dictionary</i>	Word partnerships are the heart of natural C1 to C2 language
<i>On Writing Well</i> , William Zinsser	Clarity, simplicity, and cutting clutter
<i>The Sense of Style</i> , Steven Pinker	Modern, evidence-based advice on prose
<i>The Elements of Style</i> , Strunk and White	Short rules for economy and precision
<i>TED Talks: The Official TED Guide to Public Speaking</i> , Chris Anderson	Building a talk around one core idea

Title	Why it helps
Resonate, Nancy Duarte	Story structure for presentations

Tools, practice communities and exams

Tool or community	How to use it
Toastmasters International (clubs across Bengaluru and online)	Regular speaking practice with structured feedback. Try Table Topics for impromptu skills.
iTalki or Preply tutors	One weekly session with a tutor who corrects and challenges you. Send your recordings and drafts ahead.
Cambridge Dictionary, Longman, Collins COBUILD	Check meaning, examples and collocations. Prefer learner dictionaries with example sentences.
Ludwig.guru and YouGlish	See real usage of a phrase in published writing, and hear it spoken on video.
Anki or Quizlet	Spaced repetition for phrases. Keep cards as full sentences with a gap.
Voice recorder plus a transcription tool (Otter, or your phone's dictation)	Record, transcribe, then count fillers, repetition and vocabulary variety.
Grammarly, LanguageTool, Hemingway Editor	Catch surface errors and long sentences, but never accept suggestions blindly.
Cambridge C1 Advanced and C2 Proficiency past papers (speaking and writing parts)	Free public sample materials work as benchmarks even if you never sit the exam.

Monthly progress check

Every four weeks, score yourself out of 5 on each item, ideally with a tutor or friend. Track the numbers in a simple table.

Skill	1 (weak)	3 (secure)	5 (strong)
Structure	Ideas jump around	Clear opening, body, close	Every point builds on the last
Range of vocabulary	Repeats basic words	Uses topic-specific phrases	Chooses the exact word, varies register
Grammar control	Frequent errors	Errors rare and minor	Complex structures used naturally
Fluency and pace	Long pauses	Steady, occasional hesitation	Smooth, deliberate pauses for effect
Delivery and voice	Flat, reads notes	Varies pace and volume	Confident, expressive, connects with audience
Style (writing)	Correct but plain	Clear and varied	Distinctive voice, economical, memorable

Common traps and how to avoid them

- **Memorising scripts.** It sounds stiff and collapses if you forget one line. Memorise structures and openings only.

- **Collecting words, not using them.** A word is yours only after you have said it aloud and written it in a sentence three times.
- **Waiting to feel ready.** Confidence follows practice. Speak before you feel fluent.
- **Fancy words for their own sake.** C2 is precision and clarity, not complexity. If a simple word is exact, use it.
- **Skipping feedback.** You cannot hear your own habits. A tutor, a recording or a club is essential.

Short on time? The 30-minute compressed plan

10 min read plus note 3 phrases | **10 min** record a 90-second PREP talk on a random topic | **10 min** write and upgrade one paragraph. Follow the same phases and milestones but allow 40 to 48 weeks in total, and do a longer task on weekends.

YOUR FIRST 7 DAYS

Start Today

Day	Action
Day 1	Record a 2-minute talk on any topic. Write a 250-word piece. Save both as your baseline. Do not judge them.
Day 2	Set up your tools: notebook or Anki deck, voice recorder, error log. Bookmark 3 reading sources and 2 podcasts.
Day 3	Watch one TED talk with the transcript. Mark the opening, the three main points and the close.
Day 4	Learn the Five Lenses and PREP. Practise on 5 random topics, 1 minute each.
Day 5	Join or find a Toastmasters club, or book a first tutor session.
Day 6	Do your first full drill: a 2-minute PREP talk and a 300-word opinion paragraph.
Day 7	Review your baseline against this week's work. Note what improved. Plan Week 2.

Fluency on any topic is the natural result of thousands of small, deliberate acts of speaking and writing. Follow the plan, keep the log, and trust the process.

Note: Timelines are indicative. Individual progress depends on starting level, consistency and feedback quality. Check the current availability and details of any resource or course before you commit.